

The Noble Sūtra of the Great Vehicle Called the Offering of Lamps

Āryapradīpadānīya nāma mahāyānasūtra · Toh 204 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་མར་མ་འབུ་བ་ཞེས་བ་བྱ་ཐག་པ་ཆེ་པའི་མཛན།

Toh 204 in the Kangyur is a Mahāyāna sūtra known in Sanskrit as the Āryapradīpadānīya and in Tibetan as the Phags pa mar me 'bul ba, meaning in English "The Noble Sūtra of the Great Vehicle called The Offering of Lamps." It belongs to the general sūtra section of the Kangyur and is presented as a discourse delivered by the Buddha to his disciple Śāriputra while residing at the Jeta Grove in Śrāvastī. The text concerns the spiritual merit and qualities arising from the offering of lamps, situating this devotional practice within a broader Mahāyāna framework that encompasses the four immeasurables, moral discipline, meditative absorption, wisdom, and liberation. As a relatively concise sūtra, it reflects the widespread Buddhist tradition of expounding the virtues of light-offering as a vehicle for accumulating merit and cultivating qualities conducive to awakening.

Thus is it established.

In the language of India: Āryapradīpadānīya nāma mahāyānasūtra.

In the language of Tibet: The Noble Sūtra of the Great Vehicle called The Offering of Lamps.

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling at Śrāvastī, in the Jeta Grove, the garden of Anāthapiṇḍada.

Then the Blessed One spoke to the Venerable Śāriputra: "Śāriputra, these four immeasurables are possessed of qualities that have been thoroughly and excellently purified: immeasurable karmic maturation, immeasurable radiance, immeasurable inclination toward merit, immeasurable form, and immeasurable inclination toward happiness. They enter into the practice of moral discipline, into meditative absorption, into wisdom, into liberation, and into the wisdom-vision of liberation; they enter into the individual perfect knowledges; and they come to the exhaustion of all defilements without remainder.

"What are the four? Śāriputra, they are as follows. A Tathāgata, arhat, and perfectly complete buddha, having attained the perfection of moral discipline, has become one whose mind is in meditative absorption. Having attained the Perfection of Wisdom, he is possessed of immeasurable wisdom, possessed of vast wisdom, possessed of discerning wisdom, possessed of wisdom that is exactly as things are, possessed of wisdom beyond counting, possessed of wisdom that is thoroughly decisive, a seer of what is thoroughly decisive. He is possessed of a mind supremely liberated and utterly liberated, possessed of a mind that is unwavering, possessed of a mind that is undisturbed, possessed of a mind that performs its enlightened activity excellently.

"Śāriputra, the Tathāgata, arhat, and perfectly complete buddha has abandoned all non-virtuous phenomena and is possessed of all virtuous phenomena. His conduct is utterly perfect; he is never separated from mindful engagement; he teaches the truth and sees the truth; he has become manifest, immeasurable, of immeasurable assembly. He overpowers and is possessed of a moral discipline, meditative absorption, wisdom, liberation, and wisdom-vision of liberation that cannot be overpowered. He has attained the power born of the ten powers, has attained the power born of fearlessness, has attained the power born of the buddha qualities, has attained the power born of great loving-kindness and great compassion, has attained the power born of the individual perfect knowledges. His former aspirations are utterly perfect; he has performed thorough purification in the past; he is possessed of precious wisdom; he has not abandoned his striving; his diligence is immeasurable; he is free of anguish and harm; he possesses no grasping; he is a seer of all, a knower of all — a great elephant, immeasurable, without aggregates, an unsurpassed field of merit.

"Śāriputra, in regard to that Tathāgata, arhat, and perfectly complete buddha who, over countless tens of millions of eons, has perfectly accomplished virtuous roots and who is possessed of the three knowledges — to the stūpa of such a Tathāgata who is a field of merit, whether a fully ordained monk, a fully ordained nun, a male lay practitioner, or a female lay practitioner, with a clear and faithful mind, seeking merit, aiming at merit, using merit as their provision, desiring merit, recollecting and reflecting in accordance with yogic practice, and with the excellent preparation of former practice, were to offer even a small or inferior lamp soaked in sesame oil or clarified butter, or were definitely to make such an offering —"

— or were to present it fully, offer it, or place it, seeking virtue and its benefit, and were thus to attend upon the stūpa of a Tathāgata — an arhat, a perfectly and fully awakened buddha, a Blessed One who has abandoned the wandering of birth at the farthest end of the future — and were, as they do so, to contemplate the moral discipline, meditative absorption, wisdom, liberation, and the gnosis and vision of liberation by which that Tathāgata is sustained; or were to contemplate any one of those qualities; or were, out of regard for the Tathāgata, to contemplate the Tathāgata in connection with that very basis; and, for the sake of that Tathāgata — an arhat, a perfectly and fully awakened buddha — were to arouse the thought of making offering to the Tathāgata, resolving: "May this lamp blaze, blaze brightly, be offered, be fully offered, be well placed" — and with a mental stream that has become faithful, with moral discipline perfectly pure, endowed with the moral discipline of one who is equal to the unequalled, were to pay homage at the stūpa of a Tathāgata — an arhat, a perfectly and fully awakened buddha — possessed of immeasurable merit, whether a great amount or the smallest trifle, even just a pinprick's worth, or the mere width of a sesame seed, or a finger-breadth, or even only a flash of lightning, or even just enough to illuminate a single step —

O Śāriputra, the karmic maturation of such a person cannot be declared by śrāvakas or by pratyekabuddhas. O Śāriputra, furthermore, the karmic maturation of merit — the ripening of one who, with no expectation of return, gives with faith, joy, and delight — it is only a Tathāgata who can fully set forth that karmic maturation of merit. O Śāriputra, furthermore, a son of good family or daughter of good family who is possessed of faith, who abides with reverence, is without wavering and without deceit, who reflects with certainty upon the qualities of the buddha — if such a person, having generated a virtuous intention, illuminates even the smallest and most insignificant lamp, and by the lighting of that lamp illuminates even just the step of that Tathāgata's stūpa, or its circumambulation path, or its base, or its parasol, or the whole of it, or even just some portion of it between one part and another — if that lamp then swiftly goes out, extinguished by wind, or by rain, or because the oil is exhausted, or because the wick is exhausted —

O Śāriputra, it is just as when, at the stirring of nāgas, a dense web of thick clouds gathers and lightning springs from the sky and vanishes: O Śāriputra, just as the swift arising and passing of that lightning, when seen, is said to blind the eyes of sentient beings — in just that way, O Śāriputra, the immeasurable mass of merit accumulated by the offering of a lamp, whether

by a monk, a nun, a male lay practitioner, a female lay practitioner, or any other sentient being who has not taken up a training precept — one who seeks virtuous roots, who has faith in the buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha, who abides in protecting themselves, who desires merit — however small the lamp they have offered, the magnitude of the mass of merit they will encompass in their karmic maturation: that the Tathāgata knows. O Śāriputra, even from the offering of the smallest lamp, the karmic maturation of the mass of merit accomplished by the offering of that lamp — O Śāriputra, that cannot be declared by the world together with its gods, together with Brahmā, together with its ascetics and brahmins, save only by a Tathāgata, an arhat, a perfectly and fully awakened buddha. O Śāriputra, the domain of the awakened Blessed Ones is inconceivable:

O Śāriputra, the magnitude of the immeasurable and incalculable mass of merit encompassed through the complete offering of that lamp — the Tathāgata knows it. O Śāriputra, if even the karmic maturation of an offering as small as that lamp is immeasurable, then what need is there to speak of one who performs a distinguished act of worship, or sets out to perform such worship, at a stūpa of a Tathāgata who has passed into nirvāṇa — whether with incense, or with garlands of flowers, or with parasols, or with banners, or with garlands of lamps of whatever kind, in their many varieties?

O Śāriputra, there are further four things to be understood through faith. What are those four? They are: understanding through faith that the phenomena of a buddha are immeasurable; understanding through faith that however small a root of virtue may be, its karmic maturation will still be immeasurable; and beholding the Teacher as the karmic maturation of actions accumulated through faith in the Three Jewels. If even you śrāvakas are unable to think upon or fully conceive this in every respect, then it is altogether impossible for others who do not abide in the noble lineage to know through direct perception or thoroughly comprehend the karmic maturation of karma — that is impossible. Otherwise, this is something to be understood through faith.

O Śāriputra, śrāvakas are unable to think upon or know the karmic maturation of the karma of all sentient beings. O Śāriputra, you yourselves should refrain from conceptual engagement with this matter. Why is that? O Śāriputra, it is because the Tathāgata has declared that the karmic maturation of sentient beings is inconceivable. O Śāriputra, the Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas of the past have likewise declared that the karmic maturation of sentient beings is inconceivable. O Śāriputra, the Tathāgatas,

arhats, perfectly and fully awakened buddhas of the future will likewise teach that the karmic maturation of sentient beings is nothing other than inconceivable.

O Śāriputra, the aspirations of sentient beings, their minds, and their insight are also inconceivable — and these are things to be understood through faith. O Śāriputra, even you who abide in the noble lineage cannot apply eye and discernment to the knowledge of the minds of all sentient beings. How then could those others — whose minds are untamed, who lack moral discipline, meditative absorption, wisdom, liberation, and the knowledge that sees liberation; who are forgetful; whose eyes are obscured by the darkness of ignorance — who do not even turn their knowing toward their own phenomena, asking themselves: "What am I? Who am I? What kind of being am I? Where do I come from? How large am I? What am I like? Am I a being possessed of a self, or a being not possessed of a self? Am I forgetful or does mindfulness dwell close at hand? Am I performing the deeds of the wise or the deeds of the foolish? From where have I come? To where do I go?" — how could such persons know the karmic maturation of others? That is impossible.

O Śāriputra, if even an ordinary childish person lacks the capacity to turn their knowing upon their own self, how could one possessed of inverted views come to know the karmic maturation of karma? That is impossible.

O Śāriputra, the Tathāgata is not devoid of moral discipline, not devoid of meditative absorption, not devoid of wisdom, not devoid of liberation, not devoid of the knowledge that sees liberation, and not devoid of clear knowing. O Śāriputra, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and fully awakened buddha possesses immeasurable moral discipline.

moral discipline without attachment, moral discipline that is inconceivable, moral discipline that is immeasurable, moral discipline that is complete, moral discipline that is utterly pure. And the Tathāgata knows perfectly, just as it is, karma and the karmic maturation of karma.

O Śāriputra, how is it that the Tathāgata knows perfectly, just as it is, karma and the karmic maturation of karma? O Śāriputra, in this regard the Tathāgata knows thus: "This sentient being has exhausted all virtuous phenomena and is filled with non-virtuous phenomena. This sentient being will come to give rise to virtuous phenomena and non-virtuous phenomena will cease for them. This sentient being will come to give rise to non-virtuous phenomena and virtuous phenomena will cease for them." O Śāriputra, by this entry into understanding,

the Tathāgata knows perfectly the various karmas and the various karmic maturations of each and every sentient being.

O Śāriputra, in this regard sentient beings are shrouded in darkness and lack expertise, whereas the Tathāgata is possessed of exactly such knowledge and exactly such expertise, and by means of that expertise he prophesies the inconceivable karmic maturations of sentient beings.

O Śāriputra, in this regard those who have faith will come to trust, while those who lack faith and have fallen away from this teaching will come to scorn and dispute it, and that will work against their long-term welfare, prove meaningless, bring them suffering, and lead them to a bad rebirth.

O Śāriputra, in this regard whatever sentient being makes an offering of butter lamps at a stūpa (caitya) of the Tathāgata — having fully and definitively made that offering of butter lamps, having accumulated the karma of collecting roots of virtue, desiring the pleasant fruit of karmic maturation, endowed with joy and supreme joy, and having accumulated the offering with faith — in this very life that person attains three settled convictions of mind. What are the three? First, the person thinks: "I have made offerings to the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and fully awakened buddha. Having received a body, I shall discern what in this body is of essence and what is not of essence, and shall give what has essence." With that thought, they come to see their possessions as fraught with fault, and they give what is of essence in exchange for possessions that are without essence. This, O Śāriputra, is the first settled conviction of mind born of having made offerings at the stūpa of the Tathāgata.

O Śāriputra, furthermore, the person thinks: "I have made offerings to the supreme recipient of giving, the unsurpassed field of merit, the worthy recipient of donations. Therefore I have no fear of the hells, no fear of rebirth among animals, and no fear of the realm of Yama, the lord of death. My migration will be one of five kinds of happiness: I shall attain a high rebirth, or attain the human state, or attain form, or attain enjoyments, or attain awakening." This, O Śāriputra, is the second settled conviction of mind attained through making offerings at the stūpa of the Tathāgata.

O Śāriputra, furthermore, one who has fully and properly devoted themselves to making the offering of butter lamps at the stūpa of the Tathāgata knows: "I have given in generosity. I have indeed performed meritorious deeds. I have indeed abandoned miserliness." And further that person thinks: "I am a giver,

and I have given." Thinking thus, in the act of giving they are free from anguish and free from regret.

O Śāriputra, this is the third settled conviction of mind attained through making offerings at the stūpa of the Tathāgata.

O Śāriputra, furthermore, a son or daughter of good family who has offered butter lamps at the stūpa of the Tathāgata attains, at the time of death, three radiances. What are these three? Their virtuous and wholesome deeds become manifest; they attain mindfulness and do not forget their virtuous deeds. O Śāriputra, thus at the time of death, the recollection of having cultivated roots of virtue in relation to the Tathāgata — this is the first radiance. O Śāriputra, furthermore, that sentient being who has made offerings at the stūpa of the Tathāgata, at the time of death recalls: "I made offerings to the Buddha," and thereby attains supreme joy. O Śāriputra, thus the arising of a mind accompanied by the recollection of the Buddha — this is the second radiance. O Śāriputra, furthermore, when that sentient being at the time of death sees other sentient beings giving in generosity, they think: "I too offered butter lamps, and I shall give again in the future." The mind of generosity arises, and they are not seized by feelings of suffering; and in this way a recollection of the Dharma corresponding to their roots of virtue arises. O Śāriputra, thus attending in the mind precisely to one's roots of virtue — this is the third radiance attained.

O Śāriputra, furthermore, a son or daughter of good family who has offered butter lamps at the stūpa of the Tathāgata attains, at the time of death, four radiances. What are these four? They see before them the disk of the sun rising; they see before them the disk of the full moon rising; they see a retinue of gods present; and they see the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha, seated at the seat of awakening and achieving manifest complete awakening — and they see themselves reverently joining their palms together in homage to him. O Śāriputra, by having offered butter lamps at the stūpa of the Tathāgata, one comes to attain these four radiances at the time of death.

The Blessed One, having spoken thus, and the Sugata having so declared, the Teacher then spoke further in these words:

One who is skilled and makes the offering of lamps
at the stūpas of the great sage — lord of Dharma, infinite —
through that act of offering lamps attains

boundless happiness, purpose, and gain.

At the moment of death their mindfulness shall not fade;
they shall see themselves as the very one who offered lamps.
They attain the four joys free from all impurity,
and at the time of death they pass without confusion.

All radiances they know, spreading round about;
they behold both the sun and the moon.
Tens of millions of gods they shall see,
and free from confusion they speak the Dharma of the Buddha.

Though father and mother, children, kin,
and all the retinue surround them weeping,
those things do not draw them back,
and throughout that time mindfulness does not fail.

Before them they see a most excellent celestial palace;
they also see fearless goddesses,
four parks most beautifully adorned,
and the five qualities of desire plain to behold.

Through having made offerings to the supreme noble sages of the Sage,
they see the Sugata at the seat of awakening,
and they too join their palms together in homage;
they see themselves honoured before gods, nāgas, and asuras.

With reverence they behold the guide of the world,
and going there, upon seeing the Sugata,
with joy they invite him to turn his gaze toward them.
He grants them the measure of a parasol in welcome.

Satisfied by that happiness of individual attainment,
when death comes they do not experience that suffering.

The mind rejoices even in supreme, excellent awakening,
and for such a one the great terror of death does not arise.
This is the karmic ripening of having offered a lamp:
at the time of death, mindfulness does not diminish.
To such a one the directions all become luminous,
and beautiful forms never seen before come into view.
At death, they are certain to go to the higher realms,

and they know that their body will sit upon a divine throne.

When making offerings to the Victors,
they behold goddesses all around them.

Śāriputra, furthermore, one who has offered a lamp to a stūpa of the Tathāgata is born among the gods of the Thirty-Three, and that divine son comes to possess the five thorough purities.

Śāriputra, you ask what it means for that divine son to possess the five thorough purities. His body becomes thoroughly pure; he comes to possess great divine power; his mindfulness and wisdom become thoroughly pure; his ears hear beautiful sounds; and his retinue is richly endowed with happiness.

The Blessed One spoke thus, and having spoken thus, the Sugata, the Teacher, declared further these words:

By offering a lamp to the stūpa of the Sage,
his body shines with brilliant luminosity,
endowed with splendour that none can rival,
and he becomes lord over a thousand gods.

He hears the melodious, lovely sounds of the gods.
Just as others among the gods are supreme, so too is he.
Endowed with excellent mindfulness and excellent intellect,
he attains a supremely excellent and well-appointed retinue.

Wherever that divine son may go,
all the gods set out as he sets forth.
That his body blazes with such radiance —
this is the fruit of previous karma.

In a pleasure grove, a tree called
Excellent Moon adorns a celestial palace.
Just as the moon shines with light on every side,
so too do his trees blaze with that same luminosity.

As a bright lamp blazes clear and brilliant,
sending charming fragrances in all directions —
what is the name of this luminous flower?
A thousand gods are filled with wonder at it.

His retinue and assembly, adorned with those flowers,
are made beautiful thereby.
Among billions and billions of gods, he
is resplendent as the sun rising.

Śāriputra, one who has offered a lamp to a stūpa of the Tathāgata is born among the gods of the Thirty-Three. For as long as those divine sons remain, they come to know of themselves when the time of death and departure will arrive. At the time of death, that divine son, through Dharma talk, thoroughly delights his own retinue and other divine sons, causes them to take it rightly to heart, and then passes away from that place. After passing away, he does not fall into an unfortunate destiny. Even if he is born in the human world, he is born into a supremely noble lineage, endowed with faith, born at a time when buddhas appear. And even if born in a time when no buddha appears, he is born into a lineage free of wrong views and free of astonishment at the marvellous.

The Blessed One spoke thus, and having spoken thus, the Sugata, the Teacher, declared further these words:

This understanding arises in him:

"I will dwell in divine existence for a long time."

That foremost god knows this well —

when the time of death is about to descend upon him,
the five signs will then arise.

Billions upon billions of gods gather there,
and they too teach the Dharma directly to him:

"I shall not be long in departing from here.

All conditioned existence is impermanent, devoid of happiness.

Others die and others are born.

Alas, I too am about to die."

He, seated in their midst, speaks these words, which are deeply painful to utter.

His attendants too are likewise stricken — many other gods are overcome with grief and anguish. Then he, having seen the five signs for himself, can find no joy upon his own throne. He rises from that place and departs, and even within the heavenly palace he feels no delight arise. "This seeing of us is the last," say many gods, lamenting him in just this way. His supreme and excellent throne is taken up and offered to him by the divine maidens. Yet seeing that

throne, he finds no joy in his own seat, and he dies.

The lord of the gods, having passed away from the divine realm, passes on into the human world. The memory of what he himself possesses does not fade. Even there he will know ease and not suffering. Born, he recalls his many past lives clearly, and the very instant of his birth he knows his previous existence. "The afflictions will harm me," he reflects — yet even there he has no joy, deeply oppressed by suffering. Remembering the glory won in the divine world, he finds no happiness in the human world. If even the suffering of the higher realms is so — what need is there to speak of the human condition? All of existence is without essence and is deceptive.

Whenever his bodily strength declines, at that very time he will certainly go forth into renunciation. This too is the karmic maturation that will befall him: he will never again engage in the conduct of conceptual proliferation. This is the fruit of his having offered the lamp. Life after life, through that lifetime's memory, he will not engage in actions unworthy of performance. Without doubt he will go forth from home.

He will not become blind, will not become deaf, and his eyes will not be absent. He will not be diseased, will not cry out with a terrible voice, will not become foolish, will not become ignorant. His eyes will never at any time be absent, nor will his eyes become diseased. They will not be one-eyed, nor will they be eyes that are hollow and blind. His eyes will be entirely free of dimness. With eyes that are long and whose white and dark are clearly distinguished, his eyes will be pure throughout existence. Like a gem of fine radiance, he will perceive subtle meanings with clarity. Even across incalculable aeons, his eyes of flesh will never deteriorate. Diseases of the eye will not arise for him. This is the karmic maturation of having offered the lamp.

In the same way, he will master and understand arithmetic, form, and logical reasoning, becoming endowed with patience and fearlessness. He will be wise and possessed of intelligence. His intelligence, exceedingly subtle, will behold the ultimate truth. He will look upon all conditioned existences as without activity. He will attain illumination in the teaching of the Victors. Likewise, seeing a buddha, a guide of the world, he will make excellent offering with faith upon seeing him. His bodily form will become fine and beautiful. Friends, companions, and kin will rejoice in him. He will become wealthy, powerful, and abundantly rich. He will obtain a splendid retinue that does not abandon him.

Just as a lamp, having dispelled darkness, fills all with its illuminating light, he will likewise illuminate everything and shine brilliantly. He will certainly not fall under the power of darkness.

Whoever offers a garland of lamps before a buddha's stūpa with a mind of faith — the mind that has offered the lamp will be utterly pure, and he will become the highest of the world's noble ones. He will become exceedingly beautiful and lovely to behold, and joy will arise in all the world. He will not be drawn to spectacles, nor desire ill omens, nor will he walk upon the path of the left. He will not be devoted to the wrong views of the world or to those that are paths of deviation. Contenting himself with even a petty kingdom, he will not go to quarrel with anyone. He will be free of hardship and free of sorrow. His mind will be utterly without despondency. He will never come to be doubted or distrusted.

He will have no evil intentions and no one will do him harm. In whatever royal palace he speaks, both the king and the royal court will become renowned. He will never be afflicted by jaundice or wasting illness. He will not become a cannibal, nor will he become an outcast. He will dwell well and be endowed with happiness. Illness will not arise in his body. In dreams he will not dream of evil. He will know the time in accordance with how the Teacher shows it. Again and again he will find treasure. By thus making offerings to the stūpas of the Sugata, it will be so.

By offering lamps to the stūpas of the Tathāgata, that sentient being will attain four aspirations. What are the four? The aspiration of the body, the aspiration of resources, the aspiration to be born in a noble lineage, and the attainment of wisdom. O Śāriputra, by offering lamps to the stūpas of the Tathāgata, one will attain these four aspirations.

Having declared this, the Blessed One spoke thus, and the Sugata having so spoken, the Teacher declared yet further in these words:

One who offers lamps to the stūpa of the Great Sage —
his body will become perfect and his strength will become great.

He will never resort to quarreling.

Without obstacle, the sovereign moves freely through the ten directions.

One who offers lamps to the stūpa of the Great Sage
will be endowed with celebrated wealth,
will be born in a most excellent household, rich in supreme qualities,
and upon being born will be endowed with the memory of past lives.

He will be endowed with a most excellent and splendid retinue.

He will always cherish living creatures with heartfelt love.

He will always be utterly harmless and beloved.

He will not be born in the household of one who has fallen into ruin.

O Śāriputra, by offering lamps to the stūpas of the Tathāgata, one will attain four purities. What are the four? Purity of body, purity of speech, purity of mind, and purity of friends and companions.

O Śāriputra, wherever a son of good family or a daughter of good family is born, and in that place and upon being born there, he or she will abandon the taking of life and will not kill. He or she will not take what is not given. He or she will abandon sexual misconduct and will not engage improperly even with their own spouse. He or she will abandon drinking grain liquor and brewed liquor. He or she will not harm any sentient being whatsoever with a stick, a weapon, a clod of earth, a fist, or anything whatsoever that serves as a weapon. And that person will turn away from sinful and non-virtuous phenomena. O Śāriputra, these are called purity of body.

Now what is purity of speech? That person abandons false speech. He or she will not assert what has not been seen or heard. And what has been seen or heard, even if asked, he or she will not speak of at an inappropriate time. When asked about what has been seen or heard, he or she speaks truthfully. Whether for their own sake or for the sake of others, he or she does not speak falsely. When others commission him or her to speak falsely, knowing rightly, he or she guards the truth and abandons those things that are impurities of speech. In order to cause division, he or she does not carry to this side what was heard on that side; nor does he or she carry to that side what was heard on this side in order to cause division. Rather, he or she brings together those who are in harmony and reconciles those who are estranged. That person abandons harsh speech — any speech that is wounding, envious, rough toward others, unpleasant to others, disagreeable, unwanted, displeasing, unpleasant to the mind, harmful to others, or the kind of speech that causes resentment. Having abandoned such speech, he or she uses gentle, soft, pleasing, true, agreeable to the ear, dear to the heart, endearing, gratifying to the many, desired by the many, joyful, and pleasing speech.

That person speaks words that pacify all adversaries. That person abandons idle chatter. Having abandoned it, he or she does not speak at the wrong time

and does not engage in gossip or scheming with others. That person does not speak excessively, does not speak at improper times, does not speak words that lack connection to nirvāṇa. Thus, Śāriputra, the abandonment of these impure actions of speech is called the complete purity of verbal karma.

That person abandons impure actions of mind. That person does not entertain covetousness — no covetous thought arises toward the wealth of others, the possessions of others, or the property of others. That person does not entertain thoughts of ill will; rather, ill will is abandoned. Wrong view too is abandoned; that person is not one who holds harmful views. Thus, Śāriputra, the abandonment of these impure actions of mind is called the complete purity of mental karma.

The fourth purity is also attained: the complete purity of spiritual friendship. Those who abandon lying, the drinking of grain-based or distilled alcohol, who are not rough, who are not intoxicated, who are well restrained, and who hold right view — such persons one draws near to, serves, and pays homage to. And wherever buddhas, the Blessed Ones, are to be found, and wherever bodhisattvas, pratyekabuddhas, and śrāvakas are to be found, one draws near to them, attends upon them, and serves them with reverence. Śāriputra, this is the fourth purity, called the complete purity of spiritual friendship.

Śāriputra, by offering a lamp at a stūpa of the Tathāgata, one will attain these four purities.

The Blessed One spoke these words, and having spoken them, the Sugata (the Well-Gone One, an epithet of the Buddha), the Teacher, further declared this as well:

In what the Sugata has taught for the sake of purification,
one who is thoroughly restrained in body, speech, and mind,
whose ethical conduct is perfectly pure with no view gone astray —
that person's eye is born of the mind.

Brilliantly clear in all directions, like the sun,
that person swiftly knows the exhaustion of the defilements.

That person's intellect becomes endowed with great miraculous powers.

The divine eye, free from dust and without defilement,
that wise person thereby knows the minds of the world
and knows the particular cognitions of the gods' superknowledge.

If one wishes, the awakening of the śrāvaka is not hard to find.

Such is the karmic maturation of offering a lamp.

One who offers a lamp at the stūpa of the great sage —
if buddha awakening (Skt. bodhi) is what one desires, that too is sublime.
For the wise person, not one of the three is diminished.
One endowed with the eye of wisdom comes to possess great prosperity.

Śāriputra, if a son of good family or a daughter of good family who has genuinely entered the Great Vehicle (Mahāyāna) offers a lamp at a stūpa of the Tathāgata, that person will attain, according to their aspiration and in whatever birth-states they are reborn, the eight supreme qualities of Dharma. What are these eight? One attains the supreme fleshly eye; one attains a memory so encompassing that nothing is overlooked from the crown of the head downward; one attains the supreme divine eye in accordance with the penetrating factor of meditative cultivation brought to full completion; one attains, through the full completion of wisdom, a state of ethical conduct without impairment; one attains the higher realms through merit accumulated in the past; one attains a birth of excellent leisure and endowment through merit well performed; having become as an eye for all sentient beings, one pleases whichever buddhas arise; and Śāriputra, through that root of virtue of offering the lamp, a son or daughter of good family attains the sovereignty of a wheel-turning monarch, and in that state, endowed with a mind of utmost delight and being supremely pleasing to behold, one attains great miraculous powers like those of the lord of gods, Śakra (Indra, king of the gods), together with a thousand eyes.

One also becomes a Brahmā skilled in the Brahmā realms, and attains the meditative concentration of renown. By dedicating that root of virtue toward awakening, one attains those eight supreme Dharma qualities that one aspires to.

Furthermore, one attains another eight qualities. What are these eight? One attains the immeasurable eyes of a buddha; one attains the immeasurable confidence of a buddha; one attains the immeasurable miraculous powers of a buddha; one attains the immeasurable moral discipline of a buddha; one attains the immeasurable meditative absorption of a buddha; one attains the immeasurable wisdom of a buddha; one attains the immeasurable liberation of a buddha; and one attains entry into the immeasurable minds and intentions of sentient beings. Śāriputra, by offering the lamp in this way, one fully grasps an immeasurable karmic maturation such as this.

Śāriputra, furthermore, when the Tathāgata is teaching the Dharma, whatever sentient beings offer a lamp while exclaiming, "How wonderful! The Dharma is being taught! How marvelous! The Dharma is being supremely expounded!" — through following that lamp offering with a sesame-oil lamp, one comes to hold fast to the lamp of the Dharma. Through that root of virtue of offering the lamp, one attains eight immeasurable accumulations. What are these eight? One attains an immeasurable accumulation of mindfulness, and likewise one applies the same to: an accumulation of intelligence, an accumulation of faith, an accumulation of diligence, an accumulation of wisdom, an accumulation of meditative absorption, an accumulation of confidence, and an immeasurable accumulation of merit. One comes to attain these eight immeasurable accumulations. One also attains the four kinds of precise and correct understanding, and gradually one comes to attain the wisdom of omniscience.

Śāriputra, furthermore, through the root of virtue of joining one's palms together with a devoted mind before the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha, one attains eight supremely excellent qualities of Dharma. What are these eight? One attains a supremely excellent physical form; one attains a supremely excellent retinue of attendants; one attains supremely excellent moral discipline; one attains a supremely excellent birth among gods and humans; one attains supremely excellent faith; one attains supremely excellent confidence; one attains the noble path free from all affliction; and one fully and perfectly awakens to unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening.

Śāriputra, why are these called immeasurable? Because the fruit of having venerated the Tathāgata in this way is immeasurable — the benefits are immeasurable.

Then at that moment the Blessed One spoke these words in verse:

Strive and bring forth renunciation.
Be diligent in the teaching of the buddhas.
Like a great elephant confronting a marsh,
crush the armies of the lord of death.

Having uttered this solemn utterance, the Blessed One then declared it as a solemn utterance. Then the Blessed One spoke further to the venerable Śāriputra, saying: Śāriputra, these five things are supremely difficult to find. What are the five? To obtain a human birth; to go forth into renunciation within the teaching of the Tathāgata; to take genuine delight in it; to completely

perfect one's moral discipline; and to bring the defilements to exhaustion. Śāriputra, these five things are supremely difficult for all sentient beings to find — and yet you have already attained them.

Having spoken these words, the Blessed One, the Sugata, having said this, the Teacher also spoke further in verse:

Through benefiting sentient beings for the sake of awakening,
by offering this stūpa of the Sugata as an act of veneration —
through that deed performed by such a wise one,
in every lifetime one becomes extraordinary.

Upon departing from here, praised by gods and humans —
one attains that sublime existence.

Like Mount Meru, one stands unmoved and firm,
beautiful and brilliant, illuminating every direction with rays of light.
Hosts of gods, beholding this, approach with reverence,
and through their supreme devotion they give rise to joy in that one,
offering praise and making offerings,
gazing again and again, never growing sated.

That being, marked by merit, is worthy of veneration by the gods,
and in the Brahmā realm resembles the radiant Brahmā himself.

By whatever deeds one has practiced with certainty,
through those one's body becomes exceedingly beautiful.

Who in this world would not wish for merit?

Who with wisdom would not rely upon the noble ones' moral discipline?

When one sees the Sage, one gazes without growing sated;
having heard the Dharma, who would not take it to heart?

While dwelling in this human world, one has offered lamps to the Sugata's
stūpa

and abided in the Sugata's teaching —

by that, one finds the highest among the gods, and finds it well.

"May I obtain a human body.

May I attain supreme faith in the Victor's teaching.

If through heedlessness I were to cast off this body,
let it not come to pass that I abandon the holy Dharma.

Having obtained this difficult-to-find human body —
why do the foolish not pursue their own true good?

If one harbors a mind that harms the Sugata's teaching,

after death one falls into a great abyss."

Hearing of that one's vast good fortune, the gods feel a sense of longing and offer this aspiration:

"May I obtain a human body,
may I achieve what is truly good, and may I demonstrate the holy life."

Even at the hour of death it is just the same:

one is of benefit to the Dharma, one's mind is clear,
and thousands of koṭis of gods along with goddesses
rejoice, saying, "This one is ours."

Beautiful, adorned divine maidens

set one at play in the four pleasure groves.

Delightful fragrance of incense rises from every side,
and the sweet sound of melodious song is heard.

Wherever that praised god goes,

beautiful forms are seen in every place,

and ugly, unpleasant forms are not seen —

all this comes about through the offering of a lamp before the Victor's stūpa.

Then, passing from there into this human existence,

one dwells in the mother's womb while retaining full mindfulness.

Having been born, one recalls all the lifetimes through which one has passed,
and through the power of the noble gnosis, one does not decline.

Through having offered a lamp to the Sugata's stūpa,

by the karma thus performed, through that very act,

one becomes a wheel-turning monarch, a man of great power,
pleasing to behold, beautiful in form, a delight to the eye.

By that karma performed, one's life becomes long,

endowed with the bliss of perfect purity;

one's body is not afflicted by illness —

such is the karmic ripening of offering a lamp.

Through making offerings with a lamp to the Sugata,

one is free from harm by thieves and from punishment by kings,

free from murderers, and one's wife is not unfaithful —

through the karma of that deed, no enemy harms one.

One is happy, the years are good, nowhere is there fear;

one always has wealth, fine provisions, grain and riches.

One's finest pleasure groves are adorned with garlands
and parks with many varieties of shrubs and leaves.

One sees the buddhas, lords of the world,
and on seeing them one is supremely glad;
with reverence one makes offerings to those thus seen,
and then, relinquishing royal sovereignty, one takes to the life of a monk.

Having boundless praise, boundless vision,
and boundless wisdom — by offering a lamp to the Sugata's stūpa
one comes to possess boundless wisdom.
Like a lamp, one shines in all directions.

With a great lamp, having illuminated the stūpa of the supreme being, the
Sage,
with pure eyes —
attaining a dust-free, undefiled awakening,
one shines in every direction like a lamp.

Through offering a lamp to the Sugata's stūpa,
one possesses the wisdom of liberation, the ten powers,
and likewise crosses to the far shore of the unmingled Dharma,
becoming a Sugata endowed with eyes that perceive all things.

In the pure directions, counting all the world-realms —
however many there may be, without exception —
like a lamp, through the fuel of fire —

one illuminates all of them, without exception, continuously.

Such is the power that arises from offering a lamp to the Great Being — that is
precisely what it is.

Now, for all sentient beings who are like lamps: if, having made supreme
effort, one beholds the ultimate with great power, and if, in order to make
offering to those who have become pratyekabuddhas, a single person causes a
lamp to blaze, making the essence of that lamp as vast as Mount Meru, so that
it illuminates the entire world without remainder — and if one were to offer
lamps in just such a manner in boundless directions on every side, keeping
them blazing for countless hundreds of aeons with the aspiration directed
toward pratyekabuddha awakening — then, if someone, with the aspiration
directed toward full awakening, illuminates the most excellent stūpa with even

a grass-torch, the buddhas who behold the ultimate declare that the fruit of the latter far surpasses the former, and is supremely great.

Among the countless beings of the ten directions who aspire to attain pratyekabuddhahood, each one offering lamps in just that way, keeping them ablaze for innumerable aeons, while one who wishes for the state of the Sugata for the sake of the world — if such a person offers a lamp to the holy stūpa of the world's supreme one, or prostrates before it even once, the merit and fruit of this surpasses that beyond measure.

The sphere of activity of the buddhas is hard to see and inconceivable. Upon hearing of it, one generates faith and joy. Those childish ones who, lacking faith, have not attained the supreme Dharma, are made thoroughly despondent and discouraged. Therefore, since those who possess pure conduct as their sphere of activity — those who are the guardians of the entire world — are difficult to find, with a mind of utter clarity and sincerity before the sages, obtain the aspiration for the sake of buddhahood itself.

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, the venerable Śāriputra, together with that entire assembly, and gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas — the whole world — rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had taught.

This concludes the noble Mahāyāna sūtra called "The Offering of a Lamp."

Translated by the Indian master Prajñāvarman and the great-editor translator, the monk Yeshé Dé, and others.

Translator's Notes

- The passage lists "immeasurable karmic maturation, immeasurable radiance, immeasurable inclination toward merit, immeasurable form, and immeasurable inclination toward happiness" but then says these are "four immeasurables." The Tibetan text appears to enumerate five qualities under the heading of "four," which is a tension present in the source itself rather than a translation error. This may reflect a textual irregularity in the received Tibetan or an unusual structural feature of the sūtra.

The sūtra breaks off mid-sentence at the end of the passage, indicating the translation covers only the beginning of a longer text.

- The passage contains a long and syntactically complex conditional sentence that accumulates from the preceding passage. The phrase rendered "the moral discipline of one who is equal to the unequalled" translates "mi mnyam pa dang mnyam pa'i tshul khriṃs," a formulaic description of the Tathāgata's discipline being "equal to the unequalled one" — that is, equal to the incomparable Buddha — which I have rendered as closely as the idiom allows while keeping it natural for narration. The simile of lightning blinding the eyes of sentient beings is a traditional expression for the dazzling swiftness of a flash, not a literal physiological

claim. The phrase "dan ngon tsaṃ" rendered "the mere width of a sesame seed" and "gsog tsaṃ" rendered "a finger-breadth" are standard traditional units of tiny measurement.

- [illegible]

The fivefold formula "moral discipline, meditative absorption, wisdom, liberation, and the knowledge that sees liberation" corresponds to the classical five-part dharma-body formula (pañcadharmakāya): śīla, samādhi, prajñā, vimukti, and vimuktijñānadarśana, representing the Tathāgata's complete qualifications.

- The phrase rendered "the realm of Yama, the lord of death" translates a term that literally means "the world of the lord of the dead," a standard reference to Yama's domain as a form of lower rebirth. The "five kinds of happiness" in the list — high rebirth, the human state, form, enjoyments, and awakening — represents an unusual fivefold enumeration; the Tibetan is straightforward but the doctrinal category is uncommon and may reflect a specific sūtra-internal taxonomy rather than a standard scholastic list.
- The phrase rendered "the measure of a parasol" translates "འདྲིང་བུ་སྤྱོད་པར་གླེང་བའི་མཆོག་ལྷན་པོ།" literally "he confers/grants having measured out a parasol." The parasol is a classical Indian symbol of royalty and honor; the idiom here seems to mean the Tathāgata extends the honor of a royal parasol to the dying person, though the exact ceremonial gesture described is somewhat unusual. The doctrinal sense is clear: the Buddha receives and honors the person at death.

The verse epithet "सर्वधर्माराधकः सर्वधर्मविभूषणः" means literally "the great sage, lord of infinite Dharma," referring to the Buddha; rendered accordingly.

- The "five signs" refers to the five signs of impending death of a god, a well-known motif in Buddhist literature: the wilting of the flower garland, foul smell rising from the body, sweat appearing from the armpits, loss of the radiant complexion, and failure to delight in one's usual seat. They are not enumerated in this passage but the audience would recognize the allusion.

The closing line renders a phrase indicating that what is spoken is barely endurable or almost impossible to say aloud, capturing the god's extreme anguish at his own impending death and fall.

- The phrase rendered "eyes that are hollow and blind" translates a compound suggesting eyes that are sunken or cave-like and blind — the precise anatomical or descriptive nuance is somewhat idiomatic. The general sense of freedom from all forms of ocular impairment is clear and doctrinally standard in merit-fruit enumerations.

The phrase "will not be drawn to spectacles, nor desire ill omens" renders two terms relating to inauspicious omens and public spectacles considered distracting or degrading in classical Indian moral literature; the exact referents may vary across commentarial traditions.

- The phrase rendered "cannibal" (𐤒𐤓𐤕𐤓) literally refers to one who eats raw flesh or a meat-eater of a degraded kind; in context it denotes a socially and morally debased person associated with flesh-eating, which the tradition glosses as a cannibalistic or ghoulish existence. "Outcast" (𐤒𐤓𐤕𐤓𐤕) can also denote a eunuch or a person of indeterminate or degraded status; the translation "outcast" follows the contextual sense of social degradation paired with the preceding term.

The verse epithet "Great Sage" (མཆོག་མཆོག་མཆོག་མཆོག་མཆོག་, Sanskrit maharṣi) refers here to the Buddha Śākyamuni; it is a well-attested epithet in stūpa-offering passages and has been rendered accordingly.

- The phrase rendered "memory so encompassing that nothing is overlooked from the crown of the head downward" translates a compressed Tibetan expression for a perfected, all-encompassing mindfulness or recollection. The exact nuance of the image is unusual and may reflect a specific Indic idiom for total mnemonic mastery.

The "three" that are "not diminished" in the verse refers most likely to the three higher trainings of ethical conduct, meditative absorption, and wisdom, though the text does not specify this explicitly.

- The phrase "the four kinds of precise and correct understanding" renders the Tibetan term for the four analytical knowledges (pratisaṃvid), which are canonical categories: analytical knowledge of phenomena, meaning, language, and ready eloquence. This is a standard doctrinal list and the rendering is conventional.

The verse "like a great elephant confronting a marsh" reflects the traditional image of an elephant charging through a swamp without hesitation, here applied to the practitioner who should confront and overcome the forces of Māra without wavering.

The final verse is incomplete in the source passage as given, ending mid-stanza with "praised by gods and humans —"; this appears to be a passage break in the source text and the continuation is not present here.

- The final lines of the passage break off mid-sentence, which mirrors the abrupt ending in the Tibetan source itself; this is not a translation omission but reflects the text as given.

The phrase rendered "boundless vision" for མཐོག་མཐོག་མཐོག་མཐོག་མཐོག་ could alternatively be read as "limitless sight" or "infinite perception," referring to a buddha's omniscient gaze; the rendering chosen preserves this doctrinal nuance.

The line མཐོག་མཐོག་མཐོག་མཐོག་མཐོག་མཐོག་མཐོག་མཐོག་མཐོག་ is rendered "becoming a Sugata endowed with eyes that perceive all things" — མཐོག་མཐོག་ here likely alludes to the buddha's "eyes" in the fivefold sense (flesh eye, divine eye, wisdom eye, Dharma eye, buddha eye), a standard doctrinal reference.

- The colophon names the Indian paṇḍita as "Prajñābrahman" (Tib. Pradz nyā brmā) — a slightly unusual orthography; this is almost certainly Prajñāvarman, a well-attested translator active in the late eighth century at the Tibetan imperial court, and the rendering "Prajñāvarman" follows standard identification in the Tibetan canon.

The transition verse beginning "one illuminates all of them, without exception" continues and closes the incomplete verse from the preceding passage, and the rendering treats it accordingly.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please

consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.